

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Dicaeidae

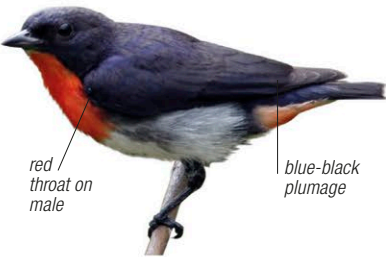
Flowerpeckers

Length 2¼–7½ in (7–19 cm)

Species 48



Flowerpeckers are small, dumpy birds of southern Asia, Australia and New Guinea. They have short tails, long wings and small legs. Males are frequently brightly colored, with bold splashes of red or yellow; females are duller, often with streaked plumage. Most species live in rain forests—but some are frequent visitors to gardens. They feed on insects and fruit, but get their name from their tendency of stabbing into the base of flowers to extract nectar—aided by a forked tongue with tubular tips. Some feed almost exclusively on the fruit of mistletoes. Flowerpeckers may be closely related to sunbirds—and share their habit of building a pouchlike nest suspended between twigs. Females lay 1 to 3 eggs, which they incubate alone or assisted by the male. The insect-eating pardalotes (p.348) were formerly classified with flowerpeckers, but are now thought to be only distantly related.



MISTLETOEBIRD

*Dicaeum hirundinaceum* has coevolved with the mistletoe plant. It has a short gut so mistletoe seeds pass through quickly. The sticky seeds then adhere to branches and parasitize new trees.

ORANGE-BELLIED FLOWERPECKER

Found in Asia, *Dicaeum trigonostigma* is 3½ in (9 cm) long and lives in evergreen forests and mangroves. The male has a gray back, head, and upper breast, and an orange-yellow belly and rump, while the female has a gray tinge on its breast and a yellow rump.



Family Motacillidae

Wagtails and pipits

Length 5½–7½ in (14–19 cm)

Species 66



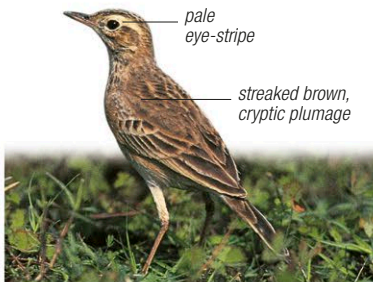
Wagtails and pipits are ground-dwelling birds, wagtails occurring in Europe, Asia, and Africa, while pipits are found worldwide. They have long legs and long claws, except for the hind claw, which is the shortest in species that perch on trees. Most pipits have streaked brown plumage that helps in



WHITE WAGTAIL

The subspecies of the European white wagtail that is found in the British Isles, *Motacilla alba* is 7 in (18 cm) long, and is common near water and on mown turf. When feeding on the ground, it pauses with tail wagging, then walks rapidly forward, picking up insects in its bill. It nests on buildings and bridges near water, laying 5–6 pale gray eggs.

camouflage; wagtails have contrastingly colored plumage that is white, black, yellow, or blue-gray. Pipits usually nest on the ground, while most wagtails nest on ledges. Wagtails are generally found near water; some, such as the gray wagtail, are associated with fast-running upland streams, but can also be found near weirs on lowland rivers. Sexes are similar in pipits but there are more marked differences among wagtails. Two to 7 eggs are incubated by both sexes or the female alone.



NEW ZEALAND PIPIT

Found in Africa (south of the Sahara), Asia, and Australia, *Anthus novaeseelandiae* is also an occasional autumn visitor to Europe. Its song has repeated chirping and trilling phrases and it has a loud flight call that goes “prreep.” This bird nests on the ground, laying 4–6 spotted eggs. It is about 7 in (18 cm) long.

Family Emberizidae

Buntings and allies

Length 10–20 cm (4–8 in)

Species 181



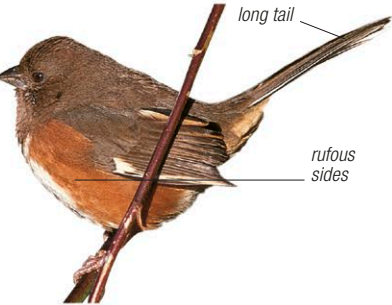
This large family is found the world over: buntings in Europe, Africa, and Asia, and New World sparrows and seedeaters in North and South America. They are small birds, with medium-sized legs but large feet that are equipped for scratching the ground to locate food. Their plumage is extremely varied, although no bird in this family has particularly brilliant feathers. The tail is fairly long and sometimes forked, and the wings are long and mostly pointed. Buntings and sparrows have short bills, which are conical and designed for peeling seeds. Most of the species live in open countryside but their

habitat preferences vary greatly. They can be found from bleak Tierra del Fuego at the southern tip of South America to the northern tip of Greenland where snow buntings breed, and from the seashore to the high, barren plateaux of the Andes, enduring extremes of climate from very humid to very arid and very hot to very cold. Their nests are cup-shaped and often domed, and are generally built low in a bush or tree or on the ground. The females lay 2–7 eggs, which usually have red, brown, or black markings on a pale background. Most sparrows and buntings are migrants. They can, occasionally, occur well away from their expected wintering grounds, but birders have to be cautious with such records, because this family is particularly popular with aviculturists, and some of the birds observed may have escaped from aviaries.



YELLOWHAMMER

Widespread across Europe (although its numbers are declining in western regions), mainland Asia, and cultivated parts of west Asia, *Emberiza citrinella* was also introduced in New Zealand in the 1860s. It measures 6¼ in (16 cm) in length and is common in farmland and open country.

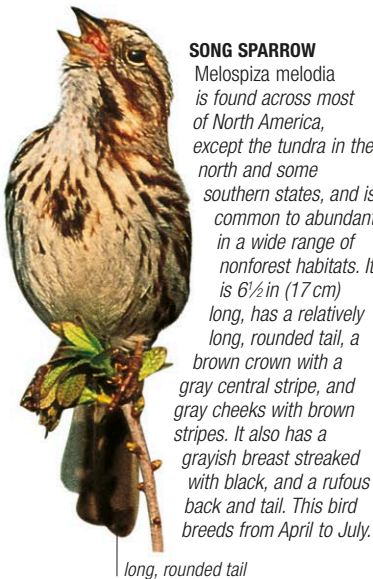


EASTERN TOWHEE

This species, *Pipilo erythrophthalmus*, and its western counterpart, the spotted towhee, were originally believed to be one North American species, the rufous-sided towhee. This bird (female shown) is 7½ in (19 cm) long and is found in eastern USA.

DARK-EYED JUNCO

A highly variable species divided into 5 main subspecies, *Junco hyemalis* is distributed across North America except the central states. About 16 cm (6¼ in) long, it breeds in forest areas, and winters in many habitats in the USA and Mexico.



SONG SPARROW

*Melospiza melodia* is found across most of North America, except the tundra in the north and some southern states, and is common to abundant in a wide range of nonforest habitats. It is 6½ in (17 cm) long, has a relatively long, rounded tail, a brown crown with a gray central stripe, and gray cheeks with brown stripes. It also has a grayish breast streaked with black, and a rufous back and tail. This bird breeds from April to July.

Family Calcariidae

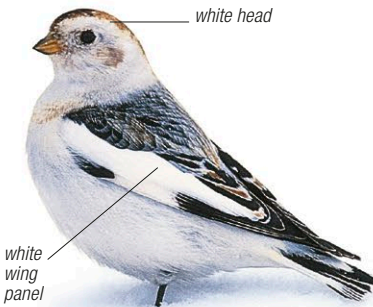
Longspurs and snow buntings

Length 6–7 in (15–18 cm)

Species 6



Similar to buntings, but perhaps closely related to cardinals and tanagers, these small, terrestrial seed-eaters inhabit open spaces, from rocky mountain peaks and tundra to open prairie grassland in summer, and more temperate coastal marshes, shingle banks, and extensive fields in winter. Four are restricted to North America, while two are also found in Eurasia.



SNOW BUNTING

Widespread across the tundra of Europe into northern Asia up to eastern Siberia, and similarly across North America, *Plectrophenax nivalis* breeds in the Arctic but migrates to lower latitudes in winter. It breeds from May to August. It is 6¼ in (17 cm) long, and the male, with his white head and wing bar, is brighter than the female.